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After Repression: How Polarization Derails Democratic Transition

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BOOK REVIEW

After Repression: How Polarization Derails Democratic Transition, by Elizabeth R. Nugent, Princeton, Princeton University Press, 2020, $95.00 (paperback), ISBN: 978-0-691-20305-8

Elizabeth Nugent's *After Repression* opens with the central challenge of democratic transitions: the collapse of autocracy may initiate a transition, but these transitions do not always result in democratic consolidation. The aftermath of the "Arab Spring" serves as a tragic reminder of this lesson. With the exception of Tunisia – whose future is still uncertain – transitions across the region have not resulted in democratic consolidation, much less a deepening of mass support for democracy. *After Repression* provides a theoretically ambitious and empirically rich explanation of the elite polarization that imperiled these transitions. Scholars of democratization and specialists in Middle East and North African politics will find the argument bold and the evidence compelling.

After Repression builds on previous studies of democratic transitions in two important ways that reinforce its theoretical contribution. First, the book offers an understated but important critique of existing explanations of democratic transitions which rely on categories of regime type. The structure, strategies, and organization of a political regime undoubtedly condition transition outcomes. But in unpacking the likely effect of regime type on these outcomes, *After Repression* draws an important distinction between repressive environments (how coercive state institutions inflict psychological and corporal harm on those the state views as enemies) and repressive strategies (how leaders assess threats and adjudicate among choices to mitigate them). For Nugent, it is the repressive environment, which cuts across variation in regime type, that exerts a more proximate and direct impact on the trajectory of democratic transitions.

Second, the book provides new insight into the vagaries of elite behaviour during these transitions. *After Repression* builds on foundational work that highlights the nature of contingency: whether elites compromise and cooperate to establish democratic processes, procedures, and norms as a transition unfolds. Whereas previous work emphasizes the strategic interactions among these elites, Nugent draws on insights from social psychology to explain how elite polarization takes root. Nugent centres the effects of shared trauma, identify formation, and group identification on elite behaviour. These rich theoretical insights provide new ways of thinking about the uncertainties that accompany many democratic transitions.

After Repression tests a general theory of polarization in authoritarian regimes against empirical evidence from the Egyptian and Tunisian transitions that began after the events of the "Arab Spring". The account unfolds as follows. Repressive environments condition the degree of in-group identification among members of the opposition. In some repressive environments, repression is targeted: only a single group is repressed by the incumbent regime. But in other cases, repression is

widespread. Nugent argues that it is these differential experiences that shape the degree to which elites representing disparate opposition groups form a collective identity that emphasizes their shared victimhood and experience with repression. Where repression is widespread, stronger intergroup identity and decreased in-group identification result in higher levels of positive affect and lower levels of preference disagreement. This constrains elite polarization. Where repression is targeted, weaker intergroup identity and increased in-group identification result in lower levels of positive affect and heighten preference disagreement, facilitating polarization.

In Tunisia, a widespread repressive environment created common experiences of repression among jailed and exiled opposition members. These experiences created awareness among the opposition of their membership in a larger group with common characteristics and a shared, collective identity. Oppositional elites were stronger and more unified during the transition: they were better equipped to find commonalities in their political agendas and felt comfortable working alongside ideological rivals in favour of democratization.

In Egypt, in contrast, a targeted repressive environment took aim at the Muslim Brotherhood though arrests, military tribunals, and forced isolation that aimed to create chaos and paranoia among members of the group. As a result, oppositional elites became more polarized in the years leading up to the revolution – particularly on issues related to the identity of the state. These developments imperiled cooperative initiatives before and during the transition and led to greater polarization between ideological oppositional rivals. Ultimately, this polarization aided the military's July 2013 coup that abruptly ended Egypt's transition.

This account alone cannot explain the specific psychological processes that Nugent argues were so important during the Tunisian and Egyptian transitions. Chapter 7 substantiates these claims with evidence from a controlled laboratory experiment that shows how repression conditions political polarization through identity. Though the effects of shared trauma and group identity on polarization are documented in the social psychological literature, Nugent's experiment carefully explores how repression shapes these dynamics. The experimental setup eliminates confounding explanations and provides more substantial inferential leverage on concerns related to endogeneity, validity, and generalizability. *After Repression* is at its best where it makes connections between these experimental findings and the real-world psychological processes that shaped elite behaviour in Tunisia and Egypt.

Elites are central to the success or failure of democratic transitions. But at times, Nugent overemphasizes their ability to steer transitions in particular directions, often at the expense of public opinion and patterns of mass politics. In Chapter 9, Nugent draws on survey evidence to show that, during the transition, Tunisian public opinion was less polarized than Egyptian public opinion on issues of central concern to the ongoing transitions. But, as Nugent concedes, this finding is suggestive. Though the link to mass polarization is not fully developed in *After Repression*, its exploration is but one of the many fruitful lines of inquiry offered by this ambitious study.

Scholars will continue to debate the ways in which the events of the "Arab Spring" shaped contemporary patterns of mass politics in Tunisia, Egypt, and beyond. Though the stories of the 2011–2012 transitions are still being written, Nugent's account couples theoretical acuity with rigorous, multi-method empirics. Nugent's provocative

explanation has raised the bar for future work aiming to understand why democratic transitions succeed or fail.

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